



RYBAKINA RALLIES TO UPSET SABALENKA IN THRILLING FINAL

Aryna Sabalenka relishes the limelight. She dances and prances on *TikTok*. She sports a tiger tattoo on her left forearm. Known for hijinks with her team, she once wrote 'MENTALITY!' on her indulgent trainer's face before the title match. She wears an orange, pink, black and blue dress with matching jewellery. In a Gucci commercial, she is seen hitting tennis balls wearing a fur coat and high heels. In matches, the extrovert from Belarus screams as she pummels shots and emotes when she wins or loses points.

In contrast, Elena Rybakina talks

softly and shuns the limelight. In 2022, when she won Wimbledon for her maiden Grand Slam, she displayed all the excitement of an office employee who learns she could leave early that day. You can rarely tell from her face or body language whether she wins or loses a point. The introvert from Kazakhstan doesn't strut, swagger, swear or fist-pump and seldom smiles. She doesn't grunt or shriek as she effortlessly strokes the ball with ferocious power. This silent assassin wears a classic white dress that evokes images of pre-Open Era amateur players.

What Sabalenka and Rybakina do

Calm amidst the storm: Rybakina followed up her WTA Finals title win last year with a solid victory in the AO final against top seed Sabalenka (facing page). REUTERS

have in common, though, is a relentlessly aggressive game and steadfast loyalty to their coaches. Anton Dubrov, who had guided Sabalenka to the top 10, offered to resign in 2022 when her game and results were at a low ebb. She took responsibility for her erratic serve and emotional meltdowns, and insisted he stay.

Similarly, Rybakina stood staunchly by Stefano Vukov, her hard-driving coach, when he was suspended by the WTA for allegations of abusing her last year. Both decisions proved prudent. Sabalenka has since captured four Grand Slam titles and has been ranked No. 1 for the past 75 weeks, while Rybakina won the WTA Finals and the Australian Open after reuniting with Vukov last August.

'Sabakina' — the female version of Sincaraz — can dominate the women's game this year, except perhaps on clay. Since losing to Rybakina at the 2025 Cincinnati Open, Sabalenka has won the U.S. Open, lost to the Kazakh in the final of the WTA Finals, won at Brisbane in January, and succumbed again to Rybakina in the AO final. During those five months, she whipped nine top-10 opponents, including Rybakina at Wuhan. For her part, Rybakina, an unstoppable train, polished off four top-five foes for the WTA Finals title and, like Sabalenka, didn't drop a set en route to the AO final.

While Sabalenka has a history of losing big three-set matches — such as last year to Madison Keys in the Australian final, Coco Gauff in the French final, and Amanda Anisimova in the Wimbledon semis — she paradoxically thrives in tie-breakers. On a perfect 17-0 tie-breaker streak before the Melbourne fortnight, the Belarusian basher edged Anastasia Potapova 7-6(4), 7-6(7) in the third round.

Sabalenka summoned her tie-breaker prowess for a record 20th